authority to order the use of nuclear weapons.'[16] In reply, Turgidson reminds Muffley that he previously agreed the delegation of nuclear release authority. Plan R 'is an emergency war plan in which a lower echelon commander can order nuclear retaliation after a sneak attack if the normal chain of command has been disrupted'.[17] The general explains that the aim was to provide 'a retaliatory safeguard … to discourage the Ruskies from any hope that they could knock out Washington – and yourself – as part of a sneak attack and escape retaliation because of lack of proper command and control.'[18]

In 1962 General Turgidson's Plan R was very much for real. President Eisenhower had granted nuclear release authority to military commanders (unbeknownst to senior civilian officials and unbeknownst to the incoming President).[19] Should designated commanders believe that general war was inevitable, and the President was dead or incapacitated, they could exercise that authority. The commander of SAC, General Thomas Power, told the President in September 1961 that if general atomic war was inevitable the United States should strike first.[20] If General Power believed that the Soviet Union was about to (or had indeed begun) to launch a nuclear attack on the United States, is there any reason to doubt he would have done what he considered his duty and launch a full retaliatory response?

By 1962 the British had also developed procedures to enable Bomber Command to attack the Soviet Union without specific authorisation from political leaders. In September 1962 a directive was issued to Air Marshal Sir Kenneth ('Bing') Cross, C-in-C Bomber Command, specifying what to do if his bombers were about to come under nuclear attack or where nuclear weapons had struck the United Kingdom. In such circumstances, he could authorise his command airborne (under the same 'positive' control as with SAC). If unable to reach the Prime Minister, or one of his two designated deputies, Cross was to make contact with the commander of the US Seventh Air Division, and if nuclear bombs had landed on the UK, 'to coordinate the release of nuclear weapons under joint control.' If, for whatever reason, these actions proved abortive, the Chief of the Air Staff, Sir Thomas Pike,